



FreeCiv: A civilisation with railroads, workers, machinery and un-upgraded swordsmen.

Glest should have had a bigger and greater storyline. Strategy games have the potential to rival the experience of fantasy-genre books. Surely the fantasy genre is about more than magical creatures and rampaging around. It's fun, but is that enough?

Conquer the world with FreeCiv

If you search around the Web for FreeCiv, you'll read of FreeCiv addiction. Strategy buffs can't quit before FreeCiv is finished, which may amount to three to eight hours (surely the Save Game concept is real?). Maybe that is because FreeCiv has you making so many micro-level decisions, that its heart-warming graphics, its gripping complexity and its rich storyline keep you hooked at every turn.

FreeCiv has a rich story. It is based on the history of man. FreeCiv rewards you for exploring your continent. Sometimes you find advanced technology through exploration of unknown places; you'll find villages to annex to your kingdom; or gold and friendly mercenaries. On the other hand, you might disturb a village full of hostile pirates! Meanwhile, multiple things are taking place in your kingdom. In FreeCiv, terrain is king. Choose your sites for cities with a strategic eye, to sustain a balance between food production and natural resources. The coastal cities are good for maritime trade, but vulnerable to invasion. Forested sites are fine for harvesting raw materials but not necessarily for food production.

The better the terrain, the quicker the population grows. A growing population lets you build more cities, which speeds up the rate of scientific development and military power. Expand your kingdom further by colonising uninhabited territories, raise garrisons, optimise infrastructure production in cities, change tax rates, construct the wonders of the world (which confer manifold military and technological advantages) like the Hanging Gardens, the pyramids, Leonardo's workshop and Isaac Newton's college; fund research in literacy, trade, metallurgy, mathematics, physics, and naturally, build an even greater army and raise hell.

You do these things simultaneously! The unit of progress in FreeCiv is a turn; it is known as a turn-based strategy game. You shift multiple units in one turn. There are no tutorials with this game, but there's an excellent help system.



FreeCol: A wagon train moves from a large manufacturing colony to a support-ore-mining colony. Also seen are tribal villages and a rival's colony (in red).

Politics is crucial in FreeCiv. Strike alliances and keep the peace, share technology with allies, even exchange strategic cities. But note that the computer AI will revoke treaties even when you are not any threat to it. Keep upgrading your standing army. You might play other people online, which can be a violent experience by all accounts. Why can't people just get along?

Win FreeCiv by shedding virtual blood, or, if your civilisation is sufficiently advanced, by designing a spaceship and sending it to the distant star of Alpha Centauri!

Though rich in graphics, FreeCiv does not offer 3D effects like Glest does. But when your imagination is harnessed, what difference does fancy graphics make? Being 2D, FreeCiv will run in 1 GB of RAM, though 2 GB is recommended.

FreeCiv is as much about exploration and discovery as about building and fighting. It gives you continuous thrills when your civilisation speeds up its technology development. Turn by turn, the game keeps you entertained. There lies its adventure-novel-like charm, and you'll play it for hours on end.

Colonise America in FreeCol

Although FreeCol is far less complicated than FreeCiv, its historical storyline that's based on colonisation will appeal to adults more. The remarkable game puts the player in the shoes of a sea-faring migrant to a new continent. (You won't have to call the continent North America.) By far, FreeCol is more story-like than the previous games. You are the governor of a new colony. Again, explore the continent no Westerner has discovered, raise your colonies on prime locations, where farmland, lumber and ores are in plenty, and maintain a respectful distance from Apache, Inca, Arawak and other tribes, many of whom are less than happy at your arrival, and ultimately, make peace with them.

Of course, other Westerners want the country—so arm your settlers! And while some tribes like the Arawak and the Iroquois are friendly, and just wish to trade with you, the Apache and the Inca are excessively warlike, and might attempt extortion during hard times. Try making periodic gifts to them, and stay on their right side. Keep sufficient hi-tech weaponry like field cannons, to deal with the more hostile tribes and other colonial